From Colonials to Collapse

The Modern History of Chinese Football (1850-2025)

Dexuan Han

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About the Author

Dexuan Han is a student at Shanghai Pinghe School completing the International Baccalaureate Diploma Programme. As a prospective undergraduate planning to major in Asian Studies and Public Policy, Han brings both academic rigor and personal passion to the study of Chinese football history.

Han combines scholarly research with hands-on football experience as a varsity player and lifelong supporter of Shanghai Shenhua. As a contributing member of the RSSSF (Rec.Sport.Soccer Statistics Foundation) database, he meticulously documents and updates historic football results, developing expertise in sports data analysis and historical record-keeping.

His research interests focus on sports history and modern East Asia, examining how football reflects broader social and political transformations. In January 2025, Han had the distinguished honor of serving as the youngest panelist at the Southeast Conference of the Association for Asian Studies, held at the University of Kentucky, where he presented his research in the panel “Globalization in Global Asias.”

This book represents Han’s commitment to preserving and analyzing the rich, complex history of Chinese football—a story that mirrors China's own journey through colonialism, revolution, reform, and modernization.

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Introduction

In Victorian Britain in the early 19th century, football, a chaotic folk game, was marginalized by Puritan and Evangelical opposition, favoring moral reform. Football's fortunes improved only in public schools, where headmasters, inspired by Muscular Christianity, incorporated it into their game ethic, emphasizing physical and moral development. This school-based football culture spread to universities and clubs, fostering rule standardization and the creation of the Football Association (FA) in 1863.

The industrialization and urbanization of late 19th-century Britain facilitated football's growth. Football became an affordable and inclusive pastime. The acceptance of professionalism in 1885 and the formation of the Football League in 1888 formalized the sport, attracting broader participation and fan loyalty. By the late 19th century, football had become Britain's "people's game," with its popularity transcending social classes.

As Britain expanded globally, football spread through British informal empires, played by soldiers, merchants, and workers in distant colonies. The value of football displayed in cultivating the physical, moral, and spiritual qualities of the British had by then surpassed that of a mere sport, becoming an essential part of the empire's soft power.

Coupled with Britain's intense colonial expansion during this period, the Union Jack was planted on territories worldwide. China, forced into submission through wars of aggression, ceded Hong Kong to Britain as a colony and opened cities like Shanghai as treaty ports, where foreign concessions were established.

It was in this context that modern football was first introduced to China. British military personnel and merchants kicked balls around in the harbors, bringing modern football to the country that had invented "cuju", the ancient predecessor of football. Initially, the sport was only played within Western expatriate communities, but it gradually spread to Chinese society through new-style schools and missionary institutions. From school football to social amateur football, the game's reach expanded.

Chinese football entered a golden age fueled by strong nationalist sentiments. During this era, Chinese people saw the vitality of school footballers accepting the western style education but play for the glory of their nation. In Shanghai and Hong Kong, nationalist-minded Chinese footballers began to challenge the dominance of Western footballers on the football field. Finally, Chinese footballers not only beat Westerners on the pitch but dominated Asian football for much of the first half of the twentieth century.

However, from the outbreak of the Sino-Japanese War through to the later stages of the Cultural Revolution, Chinese football faced numerous challenges due to the country's complex political environment. Throughout the two decades of Mao Zedong's rule in the 1950s and 1960s, football development slowed dramatically amidst economic downturns and political upheaval. In fact, it came to a near standstill. It wasn't until the early 1970s, when Deng Xiaoping succeeded Mao, that China reopened itself to the world, and sports, including football, played a pivotal role in this re-engagement. This marked the beginning of China's reform and opening-up era when football was rebuilt from the ground up. However, the sport never returned to the heights it had enjoyed during the 1940s and 1950s.

It was only in the 1990s, following professionalization reforms, that Chinese football began to see a revival. Yet, even during this resurgence, the sport faced significant developmental challenges, particularly in an era characterized by financial excess and mismanagement. The chaos left in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic has further exacerbated these problems, making it difficult for Chinese football to get back on track.

This book traces the complete chronological history of Chinese football from 1850 to 2025. Covering key events from colonial origins through nationalist triumph, Communist revolution, economic reform, and modern crisis, it provides a factual historical survey ideal for readers seeking to learn the essential timeline and developments of Chinese football's 175-year journey.

Modern Football’s Origin and Historical Background

At the very beginning of the 19th century, among the vast land of Georgian Britain, there are no games that are widespread enough to gain national coverage. Considering Britain’s future which was by then yet unclear, it was not surprising to see that not much progress was made on something as seemingly trivial as the playing of games. The empire, at that time, was still entangled in the quagmire of the Napoleonic War and suffered the loss of the United States. The sporadic and limited industrial development still hasn’t evolved into large-scale industrialization, urbanization, or economic growth.

In the future, the beautiful game of football, known as “the people’s game,” would be spread around the world, but it had yet to gain popularity across all social classes on the island. For the British upper aristocracy, cricket, horse racing, boxing, and rowing were the most favored activities and had already developed early professional characteristics such as betting on matches, the establishment of unified rules, and the formation of clubs and governing organizations.[1] Meanwhile, among the lower classes, there were ongoing campaigns that opposed sports and recreational activities, driven by Puritan beliefs that held strict moral codes and considered play and enjoyment as impious, which undoubtedly squeezed the space for football to survive. The later emerged Evangelicals, who shared common goals and spiritual heritage in their religious zeal and moral ethics, imposed increasingly rigorous criteria for evaluating all types of social behavior. Football had to endure yet another setback because ethical values were more vigorously injected into recreational activities.[2] It came to be assumed that “if recreation was permissible at all, it must be ‘rational’ and must prepare the mind and body for work, instead of being an end in itself.”[3]

In the emerging class of industrialists and merchants, football was subject to broader and sharper criticism for its perceived impact on social order and labor discipline. Shopkeepers in Kingston complained about the temporal business suspension due to accommodating the games.[4]

Fortunately, as we witness today, the game of football has not only endured but flourished. Institutions impervious to societal pressures, Britain's public schools, offered sanctuary and cultivation for the development of football before it was introduced into the new sporting and social landscape of industrial Victorian Britain.

Between 1845 and 1862, students and faculty members at leading British public schools collaboratively developed a set of football rules that gained widespread acceptance within these elite institutions. The sport continued to emphasize physical robustness, reflecting contemporary ideals of masculinity that valued the ability to both deliver and endure unmalicious physical contact. However, a significant shift occurred with the introduction of principles emphasizing control and restraint. This evolution in the sport's ethos led to a marked reduction in serious injuries, which had far-reaching implications for safeguarding the futures of young athletes and enhancing football's social legitimacy. Notably, Cambridge played a pivotal role in this development by formulating the renowned "Cambridge Rules" in 1848 and 1863.[5]

The formalization of football took a decisive step on October 26, 1863, when representatives from various southern English clubs convened in London to establish the Football Association (FA). This event is widely regarded as the inception of modern football. The FA was established to create a unified set of rules for football, drawing from various public school games. The standardization allowed for more consistent and organized play, helping to make the game more accessible. By 1868, the FA's membership had expanded to include 30 clubs. Concurrently, the establishment of a separate football association in Sheffield led to the creation of the influential "Sheffield Rules," which were adopted by numerous local clubs. Efforts to reconcile the Cambridge and Sheffield rule sets began in earnest, despite initial challenges. A significant milestone was reached in December 1871 when FA secretary Charles Alcock led a team to Sheffield, culminating in the integration of Sheffield concepts into a unified rule set by April 1877.[6]

This integration significantly bolstered the FA's authority within the British football milieu. Finally, the establishment of the International Football Association Board (IFAB) in 1886, comprising representatives from the football associations of England, Scotland, Wales, and Ireland, marked a pivotal moment in the codification of football regulations. IFAB was endowed with the authority to establish and amend the

rules of the game, thereby achieving a standardized regulatory framework for modern football across the United Kingdom.

Heading into the last quarter of the 19th century, the country underwent the culmination of industrialization and urbanization, overlapping with the rapid colonization of football among the working class of society. Instead of being coincidental, the parallels were indeed interconnected.[7] The industrialization of transportation, especially railways, expanded football's reach by enabling larger crowds, national tours, and league competitions. The introduction of the Saturday half-day and the rise in wages allowed the working class to participate more frequently in and watch football matches. Also, the gradual spreading of literacy among the workers, driven by compulsory schooling and self-help movements, supported football's growth by creating a market for related media and advertising. Most importantly, football itself offered affordable recreation and physical activity, requiring minimal resources and less risk on poor-quality surfaces compared to other sports like rugby or hockey. Its flexible organization and inclusive culture contrasted with the exclusivity of other upper-class sports, making it widely adopted and promoted across social classes.

The formal acceptance of professionalism in football in 1885 was another milestone. This allowed players to be paid for their participation, which in turn attracted more talent and increased the quality of play. The creation of the Football League in 1888 provided a structured competition format, featuring a regular schedule of matches between clubs, which helped to build fan loyalty and interest in the sport. The league system brought about a sense of stability and predictability, allowing fans to follow their favorite teams and players more closely. It also introduced a competitive element that increased the sport's excitement and appeal.

From a marginalized and eccentric pastime, football evolved into a popular team sport among schoolboys, gradually gaining acceptance among headmasters and integrating into public school education. Alumni continued playing at college and club levels, bridging social strata. Informal games persisted outside campuses. The establishment of the FA and the FA Cup standardized rules and democratized the sport, enabling clubs from all levels to compete on an equal footing. By the late 19th century, amid peak industrialization, football had firmly established itself as Britain's "the people's game," attracting vast numbers of working-class fans.

As the inclusivity and widespread appeal of football took root during this transformative period, it set the stage for the game's remarkable journey beyond Britain's shores, being ready to captivate audiences worldwide.

David Goldblatt once in his work stated "No history of the modern world is complete without an account of football. No history of football can begin to disclose its meaning or describe its course without shadowing the economic, political, and social histories of modern societies."[8] To understand football's transition from an English chaotic folk game to an unprecedented global interconnectedness and one of the most universal cultural phenomena on the planet, we have to shed light on the history of Britain's globalization from the late 19th century.

Microscopically, the British pervasive influence let the Britons fill the ranks of the military and bureaucratic systems of their empire. The Union Jack extended its territories quietly into nearly every part of the globe. British merchant sailors traversed every ocean, and in each port, they encountered established British communities of merchants, entrepreneurs, intermediaries, and speculators. These trade routes formed an informal British economic empire that stretched to China, and South America, and spanned Europe from Lisbon to Moscow, and from Oslo to Constantinople. Beyond trade, the British also exported capital and provided technicians to these unofficial economic hubs, investing in railways, infrastructure, and factories.[9]

The sports, including football, were deeply injected into the British informal empire. The sportsmanship and the robust, energetic character required by the great task of global expansion and hegemony acted as a crucial factor in the empire's ascent to its dominance. Football, ingrained in the character and spirit of the British Empire, spread worldwide with its global expansion. Conversely, the attitudes toward British rule and imperial power significantly shaped how British sports were received and perceived. This interplay was profound, making the dissemination of football and perceptions of British authority deeply intertwined.

The Beginning of the Western Football in Shanghai

Before the mid-19th century, the diplomatic relations between the Qing Dynasty of China and foreign states were primarily governed by the traditional tributary system, which positioned China at the center, requiring foreign envoys to pay tribute as a sign of submission and respect. This Sino-centric framework, however, began to erode with the ascendance of Western powers such as Britain and the expansion of the opium trade. The tipping point occurred in 1839 when the severe societal and economic impact of widespread opium addiction prompted Qing officials, led by Lin Zexu, to confiscate and destroy significant quantities of opium in Guangzhou. This assertive action precipitated the First Opium War (1839-1842), which was initiated by the British government seeking to safeguard its lucrative opium trade.

China, entrenched in its traditional state and agrarian civilization, proved overwhelmingly unprepared to confront the challenges posed by Britain, a modern state and industrial civilization transformed by the bourgeois revolution. In terms of military capabilities, the Industrial Revolution fundamentally altered the weaponry and strategic doctrines of the British armed forces. Consequently, despite their bravery in combat, the elite troops of the Qing Empire found themselves utterly outmatched by the advanced firepower of the British.[10] The war culminated in the Qing Dynasty's defeat and the imposition of *the Treaty of Nanking* in 1842. *The Treaty of Nanking*, historically significant as the first of the "unequal treaties," compelled China to cede Hong Kong to Britain, open five ports including Shanghai to British trade, and pay a substantial indemnity in silver.[11] The implications of this shift were far-reaching, heralding a new era of Sino-Western interactions and underscoring China's vulnerability in the face of Western imperialism and global hegemony.

As a part of the treaty, Shanghai became one of China's primary gateways for introducing Western elements, including sports, due to the establishment of commercial ports and concessions. Back then in Shanghai, it was said that wherever the British went, football fields soon followed.[12] As one of the first cities in modern China to open

concessions, Shanghai, with its large expatriate community and numerous church organizations, was deeply influenced by Western culture.

Consequently, it became one of the earliest cities in mainland China to develop football.

In 1850, British expatriates established a ball court at the corner of East Nanjing Road and Henan Road, where activities such as football and ball games took place. This was the earliest form of football activity in Shanghai, though it did not yet resemble modern football. Between 1850 and 1862, Numerous Western sports associations, formed by groups such as military personnel, sailors, merchants, and diplomats were established to encompass a range of activities, including cricket, boxing, horse racing, and football, were established. In 1863, the Shanghai Athletic Foundation was created to fund sports activities for expatriates in Shanghai.[13] The foundation purchased 430 acres of land to build the Xiqiao Gonggong Tiyuchang (Westerners' Public Sports Ground), a comprehensive facility featuring football fields, cricket grounds, and tennis courts.[14] The earliest football teams in Shanghai were from the American Tobacco Company, the Customs, and the British Navy, and they played informal friendly matches.[15]

In November 1867, the Westerners established the Shanghai Football Club, serving both as a club and a governing association for football. The club set rules and organized matches for its members. Over time, since the members are affiliated with different organizations offshoots like the Police Football Club and Royal Navy Football Club emerged. In 1902, the Chief Director of the Shanghai Municipal Council and British expatriate E. B. Skottowe donated a silver cup for competitions, initiating the famous Skottowe Cup, Shanghai's earliest formal football competition. That same year, the Shanghai Football Association was founded, known as the Xi Lian Hui (Westerners' Football Association) by the Chinese people.

Due to dissatisfaction with the Skottowe Cup's knockout format, which left eliminated clubs idle, six clubs, led by the Shanghai Football Club, formed the Shanghai League in November 1907. The newly introduced league represented a significant innovation in the format. Teams competed in a round-robin format throughout an extended season, accumulating points for winning the championship. This approach minimized the risk of early elimination, a common issue in cup competitions, and

required teams to play more matches, thereby laying the groundwork for an expanded audience base. It was further refined with the addition of a second division in 1911 and rule updates based on the English Football Association's guidelines. The coexistence of league and cup formats has been adopted and continued in almost all nation's football associations today. The development and expansion of the match system marked the establishment of formally organized football by Westerners in Shanghai.

However, although Westerners had sporadically introduced football to Shanghai as early as 1850, it wasn't until the establishment of the Shanghai Football Club in 1867, and the formation of cup competitions and associations in 1902, that football among Westerners in Shanghai developed a mature fan base, dedicated venues, governing bodies, and a structured competition system over the course of half a century. Yet, all these developments remained strictly confined to the Western community. Matches were held inside the foreign concessions where foreign powers had total extraterritorial control and the Chinese people's access was restricted. It wasn't until the late 19th century that football overcame this insularity and truly entered the mainland Chinese community, specifically, the Chinese students, after China suffered a series of growing pains.

Football and Modern Schools

The First and Second Opium Wars (1856-1860), initiated by Western imperialist powers, along with the domestic Taiping Rebellion (1851-1864), subjected the Qing government to successive military crises. These conflicts compelled the Qing to sign a series of unequal treaties, resulting in a state of internal instability and external threats. The incursions by Western powers, particularly led by Britain, undermined and supplanted Chinese sovereignty.[16] Thus, from the 1860s onwards, a group of Qing officials, deeply pained by China's plight, initiated a self-strengthening movement, known as the Western Affairs Movement (1861-1895) to uphold the faltering Qing rule. They adopted the slogans "self-strengthening" and "seeking wealth," guided by the principles of "*Shiyizhiyi*" (learning from the Westerners to combat the Westerners and "*Zhongtixiyong*" (Chinese learning as the essence, Western learning for practical use). The first principle emphasized the relationship between China and Western aggressors, advocating for learning Western techniques to resist Western invasion. The second principle underscored the relationship between China's feudal traditions and Western culture, with China maintaining its core identity while incorporating Western knowledge and technology to strengthen itself. These principles guided the self-strengthening officials in their approach to Sino-Western national relations and cultural exchanges.[17]

The concrete measures of the Western Affairs Movement included the establishment of modern military industries, the training of new naval and land forces, and the development of steamships, railways, telegraphs, etc. Notably, and most relevant to the spread of football, was the establishment of modern schools. They are new educational institutions aimed to introduce and promote Western scientific and technological knowledge, cultural understanding, and education principles to train individuals to meet the demands of societal transformation and modernization in China at that time. Unlike the traditional Chinese education system, which largely overlooked physical education, these schools adopted Western, particularly British, models that emphasized sports. This focus on physical training provided students with opportunities to strengthen their bodies and led to its widespread adoption among youth. Additionally, China's perceived inferiority---both physically and as a nation---compared to the West,

fueled a strong desire for self-improvement and national pride.[18] As a result, the youth enthusiastically embraced sports and all these factors facilitated the introduction of football into modern schools.

The Beiyang Naval Academy in Tianjin and Nanyang Public School in Shanghai are notable examples of football's introduction into modern schools. The Beiyang Naval Academy was founded in 1881 by a main proponent of the Western Affairs Movement, Li Hongzhang, who was also the Viceroy of Zhili (a region included today's Hebei Province and Beijing) and concurrently as the Beiyang Minister (a figure usually in charge of naval and diplomacy). The academy was led by Yan Fu, one of China's most influential Enlightenment thinkers and an alumnus of the Britannia Royal Naval College. The curriculum included English as the primary subject along with courses in geography, algebra, geometry, and astronomy, with football also being formally incorporated. Consequently, Tianjin became the birthplace of football in Northern China.[19] Nanyang Public School was founded in 1896 by Sheng Xuanhuai, a prominent businessman and close associate of Li Hongzhang. Initially, the college aimed to establish a liberal arts university focused on training new legal and political talent. However, it gradually shifted its focus to science and engineering education. From the outset, Nanyang Public School featured a comprehensive educational system, encompassing departments for teacher training, primary, secondary, and higher education.[20] It was also one of the first modern schools in China to have a formal football team, which quickly became a powerhouse among Chinese school teams. The Wusong Merchant Marine School, originating from the ship administration department of Nanyang Public School, offered maritime technology courses and was modeled after the British educational system. Due to its early adoption of Western practices, the school established its football team early on as well. Lu Pinlin, Shanghai's first recognized football star, was an alumnus of the Wusong Merchant Marine School.[21]

It is noteworthy that the student football players at modern schools like Nanyang Public School typically hailed from families with a certain level of social standing and economic resources. Many families had multiple generations enrolled in the educational system,[22] reflecting their financial capability and commitment to higher education, which was rare in China at the time. These families also likely possessed a cultural and educational awareness that aligned with the societal shifts of the period, supporting their children's engagement with modern education.

However, in most modern schools, the influence of football remained limited. This was primarily because many of them were closely tied to military affairs. In the field of physical education, under the directives of the Beiyang government, which recognized the vast gap in military strength between China and the Western powers, schools at all levels had to offer 'gymnastics' classes. These classes emulated the military drills of countries like Germany and Japan, focusing on military training, and were fully guided by the ideology of militaristic nationalism. The pros and cons of this militaristic approach were evident. It served more as military training with a mechanical and monotonous nature than as a form of proper physical education. Although it improved social discipline to some extent and heightened awareness of physical fitness, it diverged from the core principles of sportsmanship, which encompasses fair play, respect for the game, and altruism.[23] In contrast, military drills emphasized obedience, discipline, and effectiveness in combat training, which hindered sports like football's widespread popularity in these modern schools.

Meanwhile, as a product of the Western expansion into China, many missionary schools were established by Western missionaries during this period. They possessed a range of characteristics and conditions favorable to the spread of football. From an internal perspective, with missionaries directly managing these institutions, missionary schools were sufficiently Westernized to focus on students' physical education. What's more, missionaries under the influence of Protestant and Muscular Christianity thought were likely to hold an open attitude towards the game of football, particularly because of its moral and character-building functions. From an external perspective, the missionaries and their schools enjoyed considerable autonomy in educational policies under the unequal treaties, remaining relatively unaffected by the ongoing militaristic nationalism ideologies among modern schools. Additionally, with the relatively high social status and influence in the Chinese community, missionary schools attracted many affluent and progressive families that readily sent their children to Western education. All these factors demonstrate the significant potential of missionary schools in introducing and promoting football. It turned out that many famous early football players including Shen Siliang, Yu Hengzhi, Chen Chengda, Liang Yutang, and Bao Jiaping studied in a missionary school.[24]

Among them, St. John's College emerged as a pioneer. On May 20, 1890, during the college's first sports day, football was included as a competition. By 1896, St. John's

College had established a school football team, marking the creation of the very first Chinese-organized football team in Shanghai.[25] The members' backgrounds reflected significant wealth and social standing. The majority of St. John's College students came from affluent families involved in commerce, finance, politics, or liberal professions. Entering the 20th century, about half of the students were from merchant families, followed by children of scholars or professionals, with very few students coming from farming or clergy backgrounds.[26]

Due to the absence of other Chinese teams, they were limited to occasional friendly matches with Western teams. This situation improved following the establishment of the Nanyang Public School football team. Beginning in 1902, St. John's and Nanyang held annual football derbies, which set the precedent for open football competitions among the Chinese community in Shanghai.[27] These two teams, representing the factions of missionary schools and modern schools respectively, were the two strongest school football teams in East China at the time. The matches between the two teams were fiercely contested, with victories and defeats on both sides,[28] attracting a large number of spectators, not only from Shanghai. "Whenever these two powerhouses faced off, it would draw massive crowds, with streets along the route to the match teeming with eager spectators. Some even braved long journeys, taking the train to Shanghai just to witness the event firsthand."[29] There was even a chant written by the supporters.[30] Other recollections from Nanyang Public School indicate that their principal was deeply involved in the team's training and would accompany the team to matches, often delivering motivational speeches to the players before they took the field.[31] On at least two occasions, following Nanyang's defeat, the principal reportedly returned to the school in tears.[32]

Based on the historical facts presented, it is evident that, much like in Britain, the earliest football activities of a certain scale among Chinese were rooted in educational institutions, including both modern and missionary schools. Football there gained considerable attention, culminating in the formation of school football teams. Represented by St. John's College and Nanyang Public School, within certain schools, football had gained widespread popularity and the public competition between them gathered a vast amount of fans, led to the emergence of a nascent football culture, and became a focal point for schools in terms of collective honor, reflecting a quite heated football atmosphere.

However, a real turning point for these schools would not come until more than 20 years after St. John's establishment of the first Chinese-organized football team in Shanghai. Militaristic nationalism in sports remained the dominant ideology in school sports during the early 20th century. However, with Germany's defeat in World War I in 1918 and the emergence of the May Fourth and New Culture Movements around 1919---which championed democracy and science while opposing feudal autocracy---militaristic nationalism in sports faced intense criticism and opposition. In October 1919, the Fifth National Educational Association passed a resolution stating that "militaristic nationalism no longer aligns with modern educational trends; therefore, reforms in school physical education are necessary".[33] This event signaled the onset of the decline of militaristic nationalism in sports. In 1923, the "Draft Curriculum Outline" for primary and secondary schools, published by the Beiyang government, officially changed 'gymnastics' to 'physical education' and eliminated military drills.[34] This shift allowed school physical education to completely break free from the constraints of militaristic nationalism.

During the same period, with the arrival of Charles Harold McCloy, a sports specialist who lectured in China from 1913 to 1919 and again from 1920 to 1926,[35] along with scholars such as Wu Yunrui and Yuan Dunli returning from abroad and engaging extensively in academic exchanges and educational practices in China, a new physical education philosophy, the American naturalistic approach to physical education, was introduced in China and started to gain traction.[36] It emphasizes that sports should align with human nature and interests, focusing on individual development and holistic health. Originating from Western thought, especially influenced by American educators and sports advocates, this philosophy views sports primarily as a means of nurturing personal growth and promoting overall development. Thus, schools started to focus more on physical activity as a means of education and to promote naturalistic sports. Gradually, the naturalistic approach to physical education replaced militaristic nationalism as the dominant ideology in school sports, marking a transition from emulating German and Japanese models to following British and American ones.

Many schools, especially missionary schools, served originally as a means of cultural export by Britain, the United States, and other countries during the same period,

naturally embracing the naturalistic approach to physical education. Without the interference of military gymnastics, they actively applied the naturalism philosophy in many aspects while promoting football and other sports. To encourage student participation in sports, missionary universities established various awards to honor students who excelled in sports competitions both within and outside the campus, or in P.E. classes which are part of the daily routines.[37] For activities, St. John's College hosted the first school sports day in China in 1890. By the early 20th century, St. John's had introduced 18 different sports for students, organizing the academic year into five athletic seasons focused on tennis, basketball, football, softball, and track and field.[38] Jinling University, Fujian Union University, Furen University, Qilu University, and Jinling Women's University have also carried out extracurricular sports activities one after another.[39] Lin Yutang, a poet, also a notable alumnus of St. John's College, once remarked, "If St. John's gave me anything, it gave me healthy lungs,"[40] underscoring the school's focus on improving student's physical health by promoting sports, which is an important part of the naturalistic approach.

Comparing the early stages of Chinese football in China and the initial development of modern football among the British, we can discover that besides schools serving as the starting point for development, they also share other common characteristics. First, football initially emerged as a sport of the elite in both regions. In Britain, public schools are elite institutions associated with the ruling class.[41] In China, students in modern schools were predominantly from families who were generally receptive to new ideas and knowledge and financially capable of supporting their children's modern education. Missionary school students typically came from well-off families with notable social and economic status, who were usually open to relatively progressive Western education. Though both modern and missionary schools occasionally provided educational opportunities for children from impoverished backgrounds, they primarily attracted the upper class due to their commitment to promoting modern scientific knowledge and Western religion and culture.

Moreover, football's widespread adoption as part of school physical education in both countries followed educational reforms that were closely tied to their respective national circumstances. In Britain, the concept of muscular Christianity aimed to develop schoolboys into physically, mentally, and morally robust individuals, preparing them to extend the empire's global influence. Football was therefore embraced by

public school headmasters for its role in cultivating physical fitness and sportsmanship. In China, football was initially constrained by a militaristic sports ideology that limited its scope to physical conditioning and combat training, aimed at strengthening the nation's defenses against foreign aggression. It was only after a series of thought liberation movements that, a new educational philosophy naturalistic physical education began to gain traction, thus allowing football to enter a broader range of Chinese schools. This shift marked a greater emphasis on the individual and the intrinsic value of sport. However, it is important to note that, in China's semi-colonial and semi-feudal context, football remained a Western-dominated sport, initially remaining within Western circles in Shanghai for a considerable period. Even when Chinese players in modern and missionary schools began to gain attention, formal matches against Westerners were restricted and not recognized by Western organizations. Football was no mere reflection of the Western culture but also a crucial element in Britain's global expansion.[42] The sport's exclusivity and strong symbolic significance greatly contributed to its inextricable linkage to nationalism. Chinese players not only compete for themselves and their teams but also carry a sense of fighting for their nation. This is especially evident in the development of football in the society outside the school's campus.

The Rise in Shanghai Local Society

Football in the Chinese society in Shanghai started relatively late compared to school football, largely due to fewer opportunities for interaction with foreigners. But when football, as a Western cultural product, flourished in schools and colleges that embraced the modern, westernized systems and the nature-centered physical education approach, it became increasingly popular across the city. Partly because many alumni of modern schools and missionary schools continued to play football after graduating and entering society. Additionally, as pioneers of modern education, these institutions played a leading role in this transformative era and served as models for societal learning and imitation. The earlier development of Western football by in Shanghai also served as a model for the local Chinese community's engagement with the sport. The Zilin xibao (North China Daily News), the successor of the Beihua jiebao (North China Herald), was founded in 1856 by the British in Shanghai. It was the longest-running English-language newspaper published by the British in China. By the early 20th century, Zilin Xibao progressively expanded its sports coverage, particularly focusing on football. Following the establishment of the Skottowe Cup in 1902, the newspaper consistently reported on each event, providing comprehensive descriptions of critical match moments.[43]

Football, originally an insular recreational activity within the expatriate Western community, grew in both scale and influence as its audience expanded to include Chinese spectators. This increased exposure, along with broader media coverage, contributed to the emergence of football within the Chinese community, particularly among those who had received a Western-style education and were proficient in English, forming a potential readership for English-language newspapers. This increasing visibility of Western football played a pivotal role in the sport's gradual establishment within Shanghai's Chinese society. In such an environment, the emergence of football in society was almost predictable.

In 1915, Wu Xin, President of the Shanghai Education Society, organized the construction of a public sports ground to provide a venue for a gymnasium specializing in modern physical exercises.[44] In 1917, the construction was completed, and the sports ground was named Ximen Gonggong Tiyuchang (Ximen Public Stadium). It was the first public sports facility built by the Chinese, finally providing Chinese social football enthusiasts with a dedicated space for practice and matches.[45] The venue quickly became the birthplace of football in Shanghai's society, attracting people from all walks of life.

With the availability of a football pitch, Chinese social football teams, Gonghe, Lequn, and Boai first began to form. However, these teams lacked organizational structures and sufficient financial support, and thus could not be fully considered as established football clubs. The specific details regarding the establishment and composition of the three teams from the late 1910s are largely undocumented and remain unclear. However, given that these teams emerged over a decade after the development of school football began, it is reasonable to infer that their players were primarily alumni from modern and missionary schools, known for their solid football traditions. These alumni likely carried their passion for the sport to the Ximen Public Stadium, where they continued to play a significant role in both school and social football. In addition to these alumni, the teams may have included a smaller number of social players---individuals who had not necessarily received higher education or participated in school football but had encountered the sport through interactions with foreigners, possibly in their workplaces.

This type of team composition became typical of Shanghai's social football clubs which emerged later. We would see prominent figures such as Shen Siliang and Yu Hengzhi from St. John's College, Zhou Xianyan, Dai Linjing, and Zhou Jiaqi from Nanyang Public School, Rao Huisheng from Xuhui Public School, Chen Zhenhe and Feng Yunyou from Jinan University, alongside players like Jia Youliang of the Shanghai Asia Company, Huang Jiliang of the Guangzhou Traffic Police, and He Chunhui of the Shanghai Railway Bureau, were instrumental in shaping the early development of Chinese football.[46]

The establishment of social football clubs can be attributed not only to the influence of the thriving school football scene and the response to the Westerners'

dominance in football but also to the clear advantages these clubs held over school teams. In many cases, their formation may have been a solution to address the limitations of school football. Firstly, amateur clubs had lower entry barriers---anyone accepted by the team could participate in matches without needing to be a registered student. Secondly, the stability of team rosters in amateur clubs, barring major disruptions, was greater than that of school teams, fostering better cohesion and teamwork. Lastly, social clubs had chances to benefit from the support of prominent social figures, enabling them to secure better training conditions and resources.[47]

The Chinese Nationalism and Football Matches

It was not until 1923 that Shanghai witnessed the formation of its first official Chinese people's social football club, the Sanyu Tiyuhui (Sanyu Athletic Club), which was founded by real estate magnate Cheng Yize. Cheng also constructed the first private football field in Shanghai at the eastern end of Jing'an Temple Road. Reflecting on his motivation for founding Sanyu, Cheng stated, "During my studies at St. Francis Xavier's College in Shanghai, I developed a passion for sports, particularly football. At that time, although there were several football fields in Shanghai, such as those at Hongkou Park and the Racecourse, the colonial authorities prohibited Chinese people from playing football on their own land and even insulted us as the 'sick men of East Asia.' My interest in sports, recognition of its benefits, and a sense of national pride drove me to organize a football club."[48]

This statement highlights that for the Chinese people at that time, football was not merely a sport for physical fitness or leisure. It also embodied an indomitable national spirit and an outlet for patriotic fervor. Even when powerless to resist foreign invasions, they sought to defeat foreign teams on the football field. The establishment of Sanyu in 1923 and Cheng's decision to form a team at that time had deep-rooted reasons. In the 1920s, nationalist sentiments in China were on the rise, with anti-Western imperialist ideologies permeating the entire decade and reaching a peak in the mid-1920s. As for football, Chinese nationalism also became more targeted and heated at the Westerners, reflecting the hostility between the teams from the two sides. In 1928, spectators witnessed a match where British players committed brutal fouls, resulting in multiple injuries to Chinese players. The Western referee repeatedly showed bias, leading to a violent incident where enraged Chinese players and spectators stormed the field and assaulted the referee.[49]

Back to our timeline, from 1922 to 1927, the anti-Christian movement gained momentum, driven by strong calls for anti-imperialism and the reclaiming of educational rights. At the same time, nationalist advocates pushed for the promotion of Chinese cultural values and the introduction of military education, which gained

traction in the field of physical education as a counter to the Western sports promoted by the missionary schools. The "*Wu Sa Yundong*" (The May 30th Incident) in 1925 further accelerated this period's anti-imperialist and educational rights movements. Efforts to reclaim control over sports from missionary schools and the Westerners unfolded across the country, marked by the establishment of a national sports organization entirely managed by Chinese, Zhonghua Quanguo Tiyu Xiejinhui (The China National Amateur Athletic Federation) in 1924. The Westerners and their missionaries' involvement in Chinese sports affairs started to decline.[50]

Shanghai Zhonghua Zuqiu Lianhehui (Shanghai Chinese Football Association) followed to be established later in the year.[51] From the name "Shanghai Chinese Football Association," we can infer that the organization deliberately avoided the more logical name "Shanghai Football Association" because, as we mentioned earlier, these names had already been appropriated by the foreign football association at that time. This also partially reflected the subject of nationalism: the establishment of the Shanghai Chinese Football Association and its corresponding competition the Shanghai Chinese League was a response to the monopolization of amateur football by foreign residents in the city.

After the establishment of their own football association and league in Shanghai, along with the growing scale of amateur football clubs, football among the Chinese community was in a state of rapid development: The inaugural Shanghai Chinese League featured only 4 teams, but by the second season, the league had expanded to 29 teams across two divisions. Football within the Chinese in Shanghai had entered a golden era, yet the aspiration to participate in and challenge Western teams in official matches on Chinese soil remained a crucial goal amidst the fervent nationalist sentiments of the time. The world of imperial rivalry and great power politics found an outlet in sports. As tensions escalated in the 20s, even footballers who admired Western culture began to resent the exclusivity and condescending attitude of the expatriate clubs. This discontent led to the creation of independent and rival sporting organizations aimed at challenging their dominance.

During the earlier peak of school football, some schools and college teams had opportunities to compete in the first division of the Shanghai League held by the Shanghai Football Association. As early as 1918, A.H. Leslie, the honorary coach of

the Nanyang, suggested in a letter to the editor of the North China Daily News that Chinese teams be allowed to participate in these matches. This proposal garnered support from the readership.[52] However, the Association consistently refused to adopt this suggestion, and with students preoccupied with their academic pursuits, the initiative eventually dissipated.

In the 1924/1925 season, a team temporarily organized by the Shanghai Chinese Football Association representing China participated in the Prentice-Skottowe International Cup, marking the debut of a Chinese team in an official match under the Shanghai Football Association. Earlier in 1913, team "China" had appeared for the first time in the International Cup and had beaten Ireland by 9-2, but the team was just named "China" and consisted of Europeans born in China.[53] The real team of China first appeared in the 1924/1925 season and beat Germany by 4-1 in a rematch after a 1-1 draw. Then, they were knocked out by England by 2-3. Scotland finally won the championship.[54]

Despite the historic debut and memorable win against Germany in the International Cup, the Chinese teams' journey to qualify for the Shanghai League was fraught with challenges. As mentioned earlier, school and college teams have been unable to secure this opportunity due to various reasons. It was not until 1926, after much deliberation, that the Association's executive committee narrowly approved the participation of Sanyu in the 1926/1927 first-division league with a vote of 9 to 8. Sanyu made an inspiring start to the season with two consecutive victories, marking a historic moment. Unfortunately, their momentum was severely disrupted by the kidnapping of Cheng Yize, leading to a significant decline in their performance. While the historic moment when a Chinese club would claim the champion of the Shanghai League had not yet arrived, it was drawing near.

The club that owned this historic moment originated from the three veteran social football teams in Shanghai---Lequn, Gonghe, and Boai---which were mentioned earlier. After a brief merger between Gonghe and Boai, they disbanded, while Lequn persisted and emerged as a dominant force, winning the first and second editions of the Shanghai Chinese League championships. In 1925, *Lequn* was joined by the legendary footballer "Iron Foot" Li Huitang, who was raised and spent his early career in Hong Kong, and just moved to and started working in Shanghai.[55] In 1926, After negotiations involving

Huo Shouhua, the director of the Guangdong club, and Lequn's players Li Huitang and Yu Hengzhi, who were both Cantonese, Lequn merged with Guangdong and was renamed Lehua. This combination was proved to be a linchpin. Donations from enthusiastic supporters of the Guangdong club significantly bolstered Lehua's financial resources. Lehua recruited talents across the nation, including the renowned players Chen Zhenhe and Dai Linjing. Li Huitang also invited Liang Yutang, Liu Jiu, and Peng Huaxing, who were all national team players from Hong Kong.[56] The team quickly became a powerhouse, boasting a roster filled with exceptional talent and gaining widespread acclaim.

In the 1927/1928 season, Lehua compensated for Sanyu's previous season's shortcomings in the Shanghai Football League, securing the first division championship with an impressive record of 10 wins, 1 draw, and 1 loss.[57] This achievement represented the greatest victory in the history of Chinese football, significantly boosting the morale of the players and instilling a sense of pride among the general public. In the same sensational season, Lehua also won the Shanghai Football Association's International Cup and Senior Cup, as well as the first division championship of the Shanghai Chinese League,[58] claiming four major titles in a single year and beginning to write the team's illustrious history. When Lehua, led by Li Huitang, visited Britain in 1929, a London newspaper remarked, "Lehua is a secret society from China, and their secret is how to play football."[59]

Lehua's success can be attributed to several key factors. First, the team recruited a significant number of national team players from the Guangdong and Hong Kong regions. Combined with the solid foundations laid by its predecessor clubs, Lequn and Guangdong, Lehua quickly established itself as a formidable force in Shanghai football. Eight of the fifteen players on the Chinese national team roster in 1930 were from Lehua.[60] The team was characterized by its players' Southern roots, known for their speed, technical skill, and agility. Coming from well-off backgrounds, these players were also physically robust, giving them the confidence to compete against Western teams.

Additionally, Lehua's internal management was well-organized, with a clear structure. The club had five directors, including Huo Shouhua, with Yu Hengzhi serving

as manager, Li Huitang as captain, and Ma Detai as the club officer.[61] This division of responsibilities ensured the smooth operation of the club.

Lastly, tactically, under the leadership of captain Li Huitang, Lehua adopted a blend of various strategies, incorporating England's long-pass game, Australia's positional play, and Scotland's triangular formation.[62] This strategic approach allowed players to fully utilize their skills, significantly enhancing the team's overall performance.

Interaction Between Shanghai and Hong Kong

Li Huitang and his fellow regional imported players from Hong Kong and Guangdong played irreplaceable roles in Lehua's legendary squad.[63] This was the first time that players from Hong Kong and Guangdong played for a Shanghai team. Such a football connection between Hong Kong, another major center of football in China, and Shanghai was predictable. As the frequent exchanges and interactions between Hong Kong and Shanghai beyond the level of football at this period laid the groundwork for Lehua's recruitment to some extent. In 1843, Shanghai was opened as a trading port, and during the mid-19th century, Hong Kong became a British colony. Both cities rapidly developed into international trade and financial centers, leveraging their strategic locations and policy advantages.[64] Shanghai's opening facilitated its transformation into a modern international metropolis, while Hong Kong capitalized on its colonial legal and financial systems to become a global financial hub. Economic cooperation further strengthened their ties.[65] Culturally, the migration of Shanghai's literary and artistic figures, such as Zhang Ailing and Dai Wangshu, to Hong Kong fostered cultural exchange and integration, with film, theater, and education also playing key roles in this cross-regional connection.

Hong Kong has a deeply rooted football history. The first football club established in Hong Kong was the Hong Kong Football Club (HKFC), founded in 1886.[66] The Silver Shield, which is still contested today, began in 1895, originally named the Challenge Cup.[67] The Hong Kong Football League was inaugurated in the 1908-1909 season.

In the same year that the Hong Kong Football League began, the first Chinese football team, Nanhua, was established. By 1914, Chinese players in Hong Kong began participating in formal football events. Four years later, Nanhua was allowed to join the First Division of the Hong Kong Football League, and in the 1923-1924 season, it won the First Division championship, becoming the first Chinese team to claim the title. The Chinese team, Zhonghua, which split from Nanhua, won the First Division championship for three consecutive seasons starting in 1925-1926, achieving an

unprecedented feat at the time. By the 1930s, Nanhua had firmly established itself as the dominant force in Hong Kong football. Over the decade, Nanhua won seven league titles and seven Silver Shield championships, signaling the decline of foreign dominance in Hong Kong football.[68]

As colonial and trading ports, respectively, Hong Kong and Shanghai became two major centers of football in China, with the sport thriving in both cities. The Shanghai-Hong Kong Interport Matches began as early as 1908, becoming an annual event and the most significant competition between the two cities each year. The two teams would take turns visiting each other's city annually, selecting the strongest lineup from their local teams to compete against one another. It was initially a competition exclusively for foreigners, but Chinese players began participating in 1923. In the 18 pre-war Shanghai-Hong Kong Interport Matches, Shanghai won 11 titles, performing better overall.[69]

However, in terms of Chinese people's football prowess, Hong Kong seemed to have an edge. In the 1911 China National Games, the South China players from Hong Kong and its neighboring province Guangdong represented the South China region and defeated the team composed of Shanghai players from the East China region to win the championship.[70]

The exchange, cooperation, and competition between players from Hong Kong and Shanghai during the early 20th century not only demonstrated the fact that China was abundant in football talent but also significantly contributed to China's national football team's remarkable achievements in Asia. The most compelling and frequently cited evidence is undoubtedly the results of the Far Eastern Championship Games.

The Far Eastern Championship Games

As the first major international sporting event in Asia. The inception of the Far Eastern Championship Games can be traced back to 1911. At that time, the Philippines, inspired by the International Olympic Movement, sent Elwood S. Brown, the sports director of the YMCA to China with a proposal to establish a regional "Olympic Games" for the Far East.[71] This proposal was accepted and after negotiations with Japan, the Far Eastern Olympic Committee was established through a trilateral agreement among China, Japan, and the Philippines. It was decided that the first Far Eastern Championship Games would be held in Manila, Philippines, in February 1913.

The establishment of the Far Eastern Games was not only intended to promote sports exchange and development in East Asia but also to respond to the call of the International Olympic Movement and advance the modernization of sports in the region. The successful hosting of these Games marked the active participation of East Asia on the international sports stage and fostered relations and cultural exchanges among the countries in the region.[72]

At its first edition in Manila, in 1913, China's national football team members are all from Nanhua in Hong Kong.[73] Unfortunately, due to the lack of experience and preparation for the long commute, China lost to the Philippines. At the second edition in Shanghai, in 1915, the local school football scene was steadily developing, with players from St. John's and Nanyang challenging the Hong Kong selected team for the right to represent China at the Far Eastern Championship Games. The result was a decisive victory for the Hong Kong team, which went on to represent China. In the official competition, the Hong Kong team performed exceptionally well, avenging their previous defeat and winning the Far Eastern Championship Games football title for China for the first time.

From that point onward, the Chinese team consistently secured the football championship at the Far Eastern Games. During the third edition in 1917, Feng Jianwei

became the first Shanghai player to be selected for the national team. In the sixth edition in Osaka, Japan, in 1923, Li Huitang rose to prominence, In the last match of the tournament, Li scored a hat-trick in a 5-1 win over Japan on 24 May, at the age of 17 years and 217 days, thus becoming the youngest ever hat-trick scorer in an international competition, a record that still stands and only Pelé came the closest to breaking it (17 years and 241 days).[74] In the following edition in 1925, Li scored five goals; a brace against Japan and a hat-trick against the Philippines, contributing decisively for China winning its sixth title of the competition. By the seventh Games, Li's exceptional football prowess had garnered him the title of "The King of Asian Football."

At the Ninth Far Eastern Games, for the first time, Shanghai and Hong Kong players were first time equally represented, each contributing seven players to the national team, with an additional player from Tianjin. However, in this edition's football competition, China and Japan shared the championship for the first time. While this outcome was partly attributed to biased refereeing, it also highlighted Japan's rapid advancement in football, as they began to close the gap with China.

In the 1934 Tenth Far Eastern Games, China secured its ninth consecutive football title.[75] However, due to Japan's interference in the ongoing tension of the Manchu problem, the Far Eastern Athletic Association was forced to dissolve, bringing an end to the Far Eastern Games, which had endured for over two decades.[76]

Throughout the ten editions of the Far Eastern Games, China won nine consecutive championships following the first edition. Behind these impressive achievements was the fact that Chinese football had established itself as the dominant force in Asia, supported by a far stronger foundation and more robust development than any of its rivals. This dominance is also corroborated by various intriguing accounts from their Asian competitors. Take Japan as an example, in the 1921 Shanghai Far Eastern Championship Games, the matches were held on regulation grass pitches---a rarity in Japan at the time, where there were almost no proper grass fields. The Japanese players, who had never played on grass before, struggled with the unsuitable footwear. Despite a last-minute effort to modify their shoes at a local Shanghai shop, the lack of studs on the soles caused frequent slipping during the matches, forcing the team to eventually replace all their shoes.[77]

Additionally, the Japanese team took the opportunity during warm-up matches to learn several “new techniques” from the Chinese players. These included slide tackling, heading the ball for passing, and understanding that solo play was not very effective. Instead, quick and accurate teamwork was recognized as the most efficient way to avoid the opponent's attacks and penetrate their defenses.[78]

It is also worth noting that, in addition to the outstanding performance of the national team, various clubs and school teams during this period demonstrated the strength and solid foundation of Chinese football through their visits to other countries. Notable examples include the South China team’s first visit to Australia in 1923 and the joint visit in 1927 by the three major teams---Lehua, Nanhua, and Zhonghua---also to Australia. On both occasions, the Chinese teams achieved mixed results against local teams and were warmly received by large crowds.[79]

In the Southeast Asian lands surrounding the South China Sea, known as the Nanyang region, thanks to the enthusiastic support and sponsorship of overseas Chinese communities, and the fact that many players from South China had connections to Nanyang, it became a popular destination for teams such as Jinan University, the University of Hong Kong, and Lehua in the late 20s.

China’s success in Asia was paired with opportunities to challenge the first-class European teams and an unprecedented run. With Li Huitang as the star striker, China went 13 years unbeaten in competitive fixtures between his debut in 1923 and 1936.

Development in the Early PRC

In 1937, with the full-scale outbreak of the Second Sino-Japanese War, the nation was engulfed in warfare and devastation. Naturally, football across the mainland was severely impacted. Shanghai's players either retreated to Hong Kong or the southwestern regions, joined the resistance, or found themselves in a state of uncertainty within the foreign concessions. The scale of the Shanghai Football Association's competitions was significantly reduced, and its functions were eventually taken over by the newly established Shanghai Football Federation in 1943.[80]

During this turbulent period, the only bright spot in Shanghai's football scene might have been the Qingbai team, which was newly established in 1945.[81] They emerged as the fiercest rival of Donghua, the strongest team in Shanghai at the time and the successor to the once-dominant Lehua.[82] However, the Chinese Civil War brought about significant challenges, particularly for areas under the control of the Nationalist Government (KMT). The economic policies implemented by the KMT during this period led to widespread economic collapse, making it an extremely difficult time for people living in these regions.[83] Consequently, overall, Chinese football was in a deep slump during this time. National inter-regional competitions were nearly nonexistent, and international exchanges were even more difficult.

In the liberated areas controlled by the Chinese Communist Party (CCP), football struggled to survive. Soldiers sporadically played football. The game is mainly regarded as a form of ordinary physical exercise or a display event in sports festivals. Almost no venues nor equipment for the sport were accessible. Simple competitions such as shuttlecock, kite flying, or running were more encouraged by the Party among people.[84] Despite these challenges, it is fortunate that Chinese football, though barely surviving, did not completely cease. CCP cultivated a broad-based philosophy of sports, which evolved into distinctive development principles amidst the complex and arduous conditions of its revolutionary struggle. The CCP's approach to sports was characterized by active support and promotion, underpinned by the belief in the vital role of physical activity in enhancing national strength and safeguarding the state. This

strategic emphasis on sports served to advance the institutional framework for mass physical training and significantly contributed to the expansion of grassroots participation, thereby strengthening the cohesion and mobilization capacity of the revolutionary movement, as shown in the words written by Mao Zedong early in 1917: "The nation's strength is diminishing, the martial spirit is waning, and the physical condition of the people is increasingly frail...What does it matter if one is destined for greatness or aspires to reach distant goals? The foundation of success lies in rigorous training."[85]

The establishment of the the People's Republic of China in 1949 marked a critical juncture in the development of Chinese football. To celebrate the founding of the new regime, the PRC invited the Shengyang football team to Beijing, using this event to demonstrate that modern sports were emblematic of the new modern China.[86]

Sports in People's Republic of China were integral to a militarized socialist agenda, emphasizing mass participation as vital for a healthy and strong working class. Mao Zedong considered physical training as critical as moral and intellectual education, asserting that without physical fitness, moral and intellectual development could not be achieved.[87] The overarching goal was to cultivate a disciplined, well-rounded citizenry to serve the nation's political needs.[88]

During this period, Chinese football underwent significant transformation, marked by a combination of institutionalization, politicization, and elitism. By 1953, sports development became an integral part of China's broader reconstruction strategy, with football envisioned as a key instrument for revitalizing society and restoring global social and political influence. The sport was systematically organized, centralized, and financially supported by the government, fully incorporated into a hierarchical system controlled by the National Commission of Sports by the end of 1952.[89] This era saw the establishment of the Chinese Football Association (CFA), a subordinate football management institution under the supervision of the National Commission of Sports. Centralized training programs, regional specialized teams managed by regional sports commissions and football associations, with most of them named directly after their respective provinces or cities, and industry-based teams affiliated with state-owned enterprises or specific industry sports associations, all emerged during this period. Examples include the Huochetou (Locomotive) under the Ministry of Railways and the

Bayi (August 1) under the military. International matches, primarily with other concurrent socialist fellow countries like the USSR, Hungary, Czechoslovakia, Bulgaria, and Poland, served both as catalysts for international relations and opportunities for enhancing players' skills.[90] Under politically-driven ideological management, Chinese elite football players trained for "the glory of their nation".[91] Although it differed from the vibrant and diverse pre-war landscape dominated by social amateur football, the core of these games continued to embody strong characteristics of nationalism.

From the late 1950s to the 1960s, China faced the dual challenges of severe economic difficulties and military conflicts. From an economic perspective, starting in 1958, the Great Leap Forward was a movement closely tied to Mao Zedong's personal beliefs and political strategies, aimed at rapidly achieving socialist industrialization and agricultural collectivization. This however resulted in disastrous economic and social consequences.[92]

Under Mao's one-man rule, there was insufficient criticism, dissent, or rebellion within the Party or society to challenge the Great Leap Forward, allowing the policy to continue unchecked for three years. Consequently, China's football also experienced stagnation due to reduced funding and cutbacks in domestic and international competition.

In the 1960s, a new concept of "Three Follows and One Large" began to spread within the military. Guo Xingfu, a company commander, advocated for difficult, strict training rooted in combat scenarios, with a large training volume, which yielded positive results and was widely promoted as the "*San cong yi da*" (Three Follows and One Large: follow disciplines of being strict, difficult, adhering to actual combat, and large amount of training) approach.[93] Given the mass nature of sports and its ability to strengthen the body, sports became closely linked with the military during this period of heightened military readiness. One of the Republic's core leaders Zhu De had proposed: "Popularize public sports activities to serve production and national defense." Therefore, the concept of "Three Follows and One Large" gradually transitioned from being purely military to being also used by sports teams as a training philosophy. And it has gained wide and long-standing attention. It happened to mirror the successful model of the "devil training" method used by Japanese women's volleyball coach

Hirobumi Daimatsu, who led Japan's women volleyball national team to win the 1962 World Championship and the 1964 Tokyo Olympics.

In November 1964, Hirobumi Daimatsu and other eight Japanese women's volleyball had an invitation visit to China. Witnessing their 3-0 triumph over China's national and several other public training sessions, Premier Zhou Enlai showed great support for Daimatsu's training regime.[94] Consequently, during the National Football Conference which was held concurrently, officials were organized to watch the training sessions and advocated implementing "Three Follows and One Large." Additionally, they encouraged the "Three Not Afraids"---not fearing fatigue, hardship, or injury---and the "Five Rigid Standards," focusing on fundamental skills, physical fitness, training discipline, competitive spirit, and tactical coordination.[95] These strategies were aimed at advancing football training across the country.

They indeed partially revitalized the football performance. Before the implementation of "Three Follows and One Large", in November 1963, China participated in the Asian Games of the New Emerging Forces (GANEFO) held in Jakarta, Indonesia. Thirteen teams from Asia, Africa, and Latin America took part, but China narrowly lost 1-0 to Uruguay and failed to reach the top four. What's more, due to economic difficulties, the 1960 National Football League switched from a double-round to a single-round format, and the national team hardly got opportunities to participate in any international match.[96] After fully adopting the "Three Follows and One Large", along with the economic recovery from 1963, China's men's national team gained 20 wins out of 29 international matches and a second-place finish in the 1966 GANEFO, marking a temporary resurgence of Chinese football to prominence in Asia.[97]

However, starting in 1966, the Cultural Revolution severely disrupted the foundation of football in China, leading to a devastating impact in all aspects. Athletes, coaches, and administrators were labeled as "counter-revolutionary revisionists," "traitors," and "capitalist followers" and were subjected to persecution and struggle sessions.[98] Statistics showed that 47 regional specialized football teams were dissolved, and 1,124 athletes and 115 coaches were forced out of the sport.[99] The league was suspended, and training and matches nearly vanished over the subsequent years. Young players aged under 20 years old lost their future career opportunities as they were relocated under the Down to the Countryside Movement. National team coach Dai

Lingjing committed suicide due to the unbearable political struggle sessions, and Zuo Shusheng recalls that during those years, the Tianjin team's players like him were forced to work daily at a cotton-spinning factory.[100]

It was not until the mid-to-late period of the Cultural Revolution, with the United States' table tennis team received an invitation from China to visit, that Chinese football and many other sports had come back to people's sight. Recognizing the potential of sports to reshape its negative global image, China aimed to demonstrate its readiness to step out of the Cultural Revolution's shadow.[101] In the first half of the 1970s, some regional specialized teams resumed training programs, the China national team was also reestablished.[102] From April 8 to October 15, 1973, the National Football League constituting by regional specialized teams was held in stages and across different regions, marking the first national league to be resumed after the Cultural Revolution.[103]

Chinese Football in Deng Xiaoping Era

After the end of the Revolution in 1976, Deng Xiaoping, who was politically more open, became Mao's successor. At the time, Deng Xiaoping, then 73 years old and recently elected Vice Chairman of the Central Committee of the Chinese Communist Party, used a football match to re-enter the public spotlight. In July 1977, the "Bejing International Football Invitational Tournament" was held by the CFA and the National Commission of Sports in Shanghai and Beijing. It was the largest international football event ever held by the People's Republic of China by then.[104] 12 teams participated in the competition, of which 9 were foreign teams and 3 were domestic.

One year later, Deng Xiaoping became the de facto supreme leader of China. Deng showed great commitment to sports, and it extended to his broader support for the development of the entire sports sector. He emphasized the importance of sports to the nation's economy and culture, believing that the success of sports could have a significant impact, inspiring the public and attracting widespread interest.[105]

Against this backdrop, the National Football League was modified in the competition system.[106] In 1978, a double round-robin format was first introduced to the National Football League. By 1984, the League transitioned from a centralized tournament format to a home-and-away system, allowing teams to play matches at their respective home venues and visit their opponents' stadiums. In 1987, the key changes of the introduction of two divisions within the top-tier league were made, creating the Jia A and Jia B groups. The inaugural Jia A League of 1987 was experimental, using a double round-robin tournament format without a relegation system. In 1988, the league returned to a single-round-robin format without division. By 1989, the Jia A League was formally established, with the top eight teams from the 1988 season qualifying to participate. This structure remained stable until 1992.

With the domestic football league returning to a stable path after reestablishment, Chinese football teams began to demonstrate their strength on the Asian stage. In 1985, the Liaoning Team participated in the Asian Club Cup as the previous year's National

Football League champion, becoming the first team from the People's Republic of China to compete in an international tournament held by Asian Football Confederation (AFC). On April 29, 1990, Liaoning played to a 1-1 draw against Japan's Nissan Motors at Shenyang's Wulihe Stadium. Having secured a 2-1 victory in the away leg on April 22, Liaoning won the 1989/1990 Asian Club Championship, marking the first time a Chinese football team had claimed a title in an Asian club competition.[107]

This reestablishment of Chinese football was also contributed by the increased amount of international exchanges. The Bejing International Football Invitational Tournament has welcomed a new leader of the country; it also changed the Chinese football landscape by opening up opportunities for much more international exchanges: the national team, or sometimes the regional specialized teams, to host prestigious clubs, such as the visit of New York Cosmos, featuring legendary players like Beckenbauer and Pelé later in August 1977. In fact, following the gradual recovery of football in the 1970s, a variety of professional and amateur teams from Asia, Africa, and the Americas visited China for friendly matches. The period after China's Reform and Opening-Up even saw the arrival of top-class European clubs like West Bromwich Albion, Norwich City from England, and Italy's Inter Milan. Each of these invitational or friendly matches often drew crowds of tens of thousands. On the other hand, the Chinese national team also traveled abroad, playing in Africa, Europe, and the Americas, where they were warmly welcomed and attracted significant local attention. The abundance of international match opportunities, along with the attention from both the government and the general public, laid a solid foundation for the re-establishment of Chinese football after the Cultural Revolution.

The Influence of “Juguo Tizhi”

From the early 20th century to the period of the People’s Republic, the identity of Chinese football players evolved from that of amateur players---such as students and employees---to professional athletes. This transformation became especially pronounced with the development from regional specialized teams to the implementation of the nationwide “Juguo Tizhi” (whole-nation system). This approach concentrates the nation’s resources to systematically train, manage, and pay salaries to the selected athletes, integrating them into institutions overseen by the National Commission of Sports. The athletes, serving as employees of state-owned organizations in effect, progress through a structured pipeline: starting at county-level amateur sports schools, advancing to city or provincial schools, moving to provincial specialized teams, and ultimately joining the national team.[108]

Juguo tizhi and specialization became a key element in China’s rise in sports. Especially for sports like table tennis, gymnastics, and diving. With their lower training costs and less intense international competition, these smaller, less popular sports offered a higher return in terms of gold medals, making them priority areas for development under the Juguo Tizhi system. In contrast, football, as a large-scale and highly popular team sport, required significant investment and faced fierce competition, while its outcomes in terms of medal guarantees were far less certain. As a result, under the socialist centrality of the state and its ability to mobilize and coordinate various productive sectors,[109] though being continuously developed, football did not receive the same level of resource allocation and development opportunities as those smaller sports. After all, the strategy had the ultimate goal of achieving international success.[110]

To conclude this period after the Cultural Revolution, Chinese football had just underwent a state of near-blankness. However, the level of development was difficult to advance significantly, forming a stark contrast to the pre-Republic period, when Chinese football had dominated in Asia and even held some competitiveness on the world stage. During this period, the Chinese national team consistently hovered near the bottom of Asia’s top-tier teams. From the time football began to recover in 1970 until the professionalization reforms began in 1993, China only participated in the qualifying rounds for seven major continental tournaments: the 1980, 1984, 1988, and

1992 Olympics, and the 1982, 1986, and 1990 World Cups. Of these, they qualified for only one tournament—the 1988 Olympics. Aside from this, their most notable achievements were merely finishing third in the 1976 AFC Asian Cup, earning a bronze medal in the 1978 Asian Games, and finishing as runners-up in the 1984 AFC Asian Cup.[111]

China's main rivals were teams like Syria, Iraq, Iran, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, North Korea, South Korea, Thailand, and New Zealand. Syria, Iraq, Iran, and New Zealand, with their physical and tough playing styles, posed challenges that the Chinese team struggled to adapt to, while teams like Saudi Arabia, Thailand, Kuwait, North Korea, and South Korea, with their technical skill and agility, often outmaneuvered the Chinese team.[112]

On the surface, poor psychological resilience seemed to be a common issue for the Chinese national team in the 1980s and 1990s, leading to frequent defeats by opponents of lesser strength. For example, in the 1986 World Cup qualifiers, China lost to the Hong Kong representative team on home soil.[113] In the final stage of the 1990 World Cup qualifiers, China lost two matches against the UAE and Qatar, conceding two goals in the last three minutes after leading by one, turning victory into defeat.[114] During the first round of the 1994 World Cup qualifiers, they were eliminated early after losing away to Iraq and the underdog Yemen.[115] In the 1998 World Cup qualifiers, China lost a crucial home match to Qatar, delaying their qualification for higher-level international tournaments.[116]

Additionally, starting in the 1990s, as football standards improved in other Asian countries like Saudi Arabia, Iran, Japan, and South Korea, China's stagnation in football development became even more evident.

At a deeper level, in terms of player development, the national team coach in 1974, Ren Bin, once pointed out that speed, movement frequency, and determination were areas that needed to be prioritized in training.[117] On a tactical level, throughout the 1980s, both the Chinese national team and the broader Chinese football landscape were characterized by outdated and monotonous tactical thinking. They relied heavily on crosses from the wings and having tall forwards make runs in the center, lacking the ability to take advantage of opportunities and break down tight defenses when facing weaker teams. The mediocrity of the Chinese team was also partly due to its coaches. In the 1988 Asian Cup, China only needed a draw against Saudi Arabia to advance, but

they ultimately lost and were eliminated. In the post-match press conference, the national team coach, Gao Fengwen, denied having instructed the team to play defensively and unprofessionally placed all the blame on the players.[118] That same year, AFC Secretary General Velappan, when meeting Chinese journalists accompanied by China Football Association Secretary General Chen Chengda, bluntly pointed out that China's erratic performance and stagnation were fundamentally due to poor coaching.[119]

On the other hand, under the post-Cultural Revolution China, football had not yet completely escaped political influence and had merely shifted from being a banned item during political movements to becoming a tool for political exchange. The national team often played against low-level amateur teams from socialist allied countries in Africa and lacked regular competition with Asian national teams and strong opponents from Europe and the Americas. Although they gained some practical match experience, it did little to improve their level. Moreover, under the implementation of Juguo Tizhi, the pursuit of glory in the Asian Games, Olympics, and World Cup became almost obsessive. To prepare for qualifying matches, the national team frequently withdrew players from league teams for extended training camps. Local teams were also often required to play warm-up matches against the national team. The scheduling of the domestic league was also subordinated to the "national team first" policy, frequently being disrupted to accommodate training camps and qualifying matches.

Professionalization

On January 30, 1992, China's Olympic football team was defeated by South Korea in a qualifier for the Barcelona Olympics, an event that garnered nationwide attention on the problem of football's development methods and thus spurred the National Commission of Sports and CFA to intensify its commitment to a football reform.[120] Professionalism reform, an approach widely embraced by European football powerhouses since decades even a century ago, was proposed.[121] However, the proposal caused controversies many viewed the changes as capitalist practices in conflict with the country's national conditions.

However, after Deng Xiaoping, who though had already retired from the top position but was still widely considered the de facto leader of the country at that time, made his speeches and remarks when traveling to Shenzhen, Zhuhai, Guangzhou, and Shanghai, from January 18 to February 21, 1992, on his Southern Tour, the proposal gradually gained proponents. The Tour resumed and reinforced the "Reforms and Opening-up" program in mainland China, which had stalled following the military crackdown on the 1989 Tiananmen Square protests.[122]

Deng's nominal successor, Jiang Zemin's promoted a socialist market economy, also let the concerns diminished.[123] The professional football industry, as a potential sector of the economy, was supported by a consensus of reform. In May 1992, following the Olympic team's failure to qualify for the Olympics, the Chinese Football Association took the first step towards reform by deciding to hire a foreign coach for the national team. This decision was influenced by a commitment from the German company Volkswagen to cover all expenses, including the salary of the foreign coach. As a result, the CFA ultimately chose to appoint a German coach.[124]

Two candidates were considered. The first was Eckhard Krautzun, recommended by the German Football Association. Krautzun had previously worked as a technical advisor for the South Korean national team in 1964 and had expressed interest in the Chinese national team through FIFA's Technical Director, Walter Gagg, who endorsed

Krautzun's high theoretical expertise and coaching skills, considering him an ideal candidate.[125]

The second candidate, recommended by former Chinese international Gu Guangming, was Klaus Schlappner, who had coached the German club Darmstadt, where Gu was playing, and led Mannheim to a sixth-place finish in the Bundesliga in the 1984/1985 season. Schlappner was more familiar to Chinese fans, having coached Mannheim to a victory over the Chinese national team in the 1984 Great Wall Cup. His success with weaker teams also earned him high praise from Chinese coaches.[126]

On May 6, CFA Technical Director Ma Kejian traveled to Frankfurt to interview both candidates. By May 24, the CFA reached an agreement with Volkswagen and Schlappner to appoint him as the first foreign head coach of the Chinese national team. On June 24, 1992, the CFA and Volkswagen formally signed the contract at the Great Hall of the People, officially marking Schlappner as the first-ever foreign coach of China's national football team.[127]

Meanwhile, in June 1992, the National Commission of Sports held the *Hongshankou Conference*, in the outskirts of Beijing, at the original location of the Bayi sports team. The Conference outlined key reforms, including the professionalization of football and the establishment of professional football clubs. In 1993, Chinese officials conducted research trips to Europe and the U.S. to study professional football systems, which informed the development of Chinese football reforms. In the same October, the Chinese Football Association's meeting at Bangchuidao (Bangchui Island) in Dalian officially determined that the 1994 Jia A League would become a professional league. The league would align with international standards, allowing the introduction of foreign players and coaches, and implementing a home-and-away match system. The meeting also discussed and revised the "Ten-Year Development Plan for Chinese Football", setting the goals for the national team to qualify for the 1998 World Cup and reach the round of 16 by 2002.

The launch of the Jia A League in 1994 signaled the commencement of the substantive phase of China's football professionalization reform.[128] The opening match on April 17 between Sichuan Quanxing and Liaoning Yuandong took place at the Chengdu Sports Center, drawing nearly 40,000 spectators. The inaugural season

featured 12 teams, and approximately 150,000 fans attended matches. Throughout the season, the league attracted over 2.2 million spectators, with an average attendance of about 20,000 per match. Live broadcasts by China Central Television (CCTV) maintained a consistent viewership of over 4%, translating to approximately 200 million cumulative viewers.[129] As attention increased and capital flowed in, the professionalization of Chinese football leagues had a comprehensive and profound impact, significantly transforming the league's operations and development model in many aspects.

The opening of the doors to foreign players and coaches marked a turning point. One of the first foreign players in the professional era was Russian striker Vladimir Nakhratov, who played for Shanghai Shenhua in 1994. Scoring 11 goals that season, he became Shenhua's top scorer, despite having previously played only for amateur teams in Saint Petersburg and being a university student before joining the club. Similarly, Marcello Mameiro, who played for Sichuan Quanxing from 1995 to 1997, had only played in the amateur Rio de Janeiro state second division in Brazil. These examples, while somewhat ironic, reflect the early stages of the professional league when domestic players were not yet at their peak, and club managers lacked the global football knowledge necessary to select top-tier foreign talent. Nevertheless, once China saw the impact of even amateur foreign players, the quality of foreign signings steadily improved. The wealthy clubs brought in international players, such as the skillful midfielder Christian Perez, who represented the France national team to participate in the 1992 UEFA European Football Championship and later joined Shanghai Shenhua in 1996. Beijing Guoan signed the Paraguayan attacking midfielder Jorge Campos in 1998, who is a two-time World Cup participant. Shandong Luneng benefited from Yugoslav goalkeeper Sasa Petrović, who set a record of conceding just 13 goals in the 1999 season, a Chinese record yet to be broken. These international players, whose skills far exceeded those of Chinese domestic players, became the absolute core of the squads.

In terms of foreign coaches, early in the professionalization period, clubs often hired foreign coaches under a mentality of "foreign superiority", leading to a wide range in the quality of coaching. However, after several years of experimentation, clubs became more rational in their selection, eventually bringing in world-class coaches like Ljubomir Petrović, who had previously won the UEFA Champions League and led

teams such as Beijing Guoan and Shanghai Shenhua to league success. The overall improvement in foreign coaching signaled that the Chinese professional league was gradually maturing and that football administrators were adopting more sophisticated management approaches.

While foreign players and coaches began arriving in China, top Chinese players also sought opportunities to step out of their comfort zones and compete on larger stages. In August 1998, several Chinese players made their mark in Europe. Li Jinyu from Liaoning transferred to AS Nancy in France, Yang Chen from Beijing Guoan was loaned to Eintracht Frankfurt in Germany, and Fan Zhiyi from Shanghai Shenhua along with Sun Jihai from Dalian Wanda both joined Crystal Palace in England, other examples include Zhou Ning, Ma Mingyu, Xie Hui, Li Bing, etc. Not only the number but also the ability of Chinese players in their teams reached a peak during this period. Yang Chen made 94 appearances for Eintracht Frankfurt, scoring 21 goals, and on August 19, 2021, he was named a "Bundesliga Legend" by the German Football League Association.[130] Fan Zhiyi made 88 appearances for Crystal Palace, establishing himself as an important and popular figure with local fans. He even briefly served as the team captain. Sun Jihai, meanwhile, made 130 appearances for Manchester City after leaving Crystal Palace, becoming the first East Asian footballer to score in the Premier League when he netted a goal for Manchester City in 2002.[131] These examples marked a significant milestone in the international presence of Chinese players, following the earlier contributions of players like Xie Yuxin joining FC Zwolle and Gu Guangming joining SV Darmstadt 98 in 1987, and Jia Xiuquan together with Liu Haiguang both joining FK Partizan in 1988.[132]

The injection of corporate capital also made the collaboration between the CFA and companies---who became key stakeholders in the football industry following professionalization---expand beyond merely running clubs under the CFA's supervision, opening up new possibilities. Before this reform, Chinese football youth training primarily relied on local specialized teams or sports regiment-affiliated youth teams. Opportunities for young players to go abroad for further training or participate in international exchanges, including international matches, were quite limited. An innovative and pioneering approach to change such a situation took place in 1993. The Guangdong Jianlibao Group partnered with the CFA to establish a youth football team. This initiative involved sending promising young players to live in São Paulo, Brazil,

for a 2-year long comprehensive football training, during which they participated in local leagues and friendly matches. Notable players from this program included Li Tie, Li Jinyu, Zhang Xiaorui, and Sui Dongliang, who represented China's national team to play in the 1998 World Cup qualifiers.

Player salaries also transformed. Before professionalization, athletes in the regional specialized teams earned a meager monthly salary of around 100 yuan. After the professionalization, wages increased dramatically. In 1994, Sichuan Quanxing's main player, Wei Qun, received his first bonus of 2,000 RMB.[133] In finer detail, Wang Maojun, Sichuan Quanxing's former vice general manager, recalled that players were offered breakfast with about 10 options and lunch with over 20 types of dishes, including numerous snacks and fruits.[134] The players' daily meal allowance had also increased significantly---from 3 RMB per day in 1989 to over 50 RMB after professionalization. For context, during the mid-1990s, the average monthly salary in China was less than 460 RMB.[135]

The Dilemma of Reform

From centrally managed regional professional teams to lavish funding, independent professional clubs, the rapid and aggressive professionalization reforms were proposed and implemented within just two years, from 1992 to 1994. Although these reforms gave Chinese football a completely new look, they also exposed underlying issues. Many football institutions struggled to break free from the inertia of their old development models and found it difficult to adapt to the new professionalized framework. China witnessed the emergence of its first professional football clubs in late 1992 after the historic Hongshankou Conference. However, many of these entities remained highly integrated with their original local sports bureaus and closely aligned with government structures. It was not until December 10, 1993, with the combination of household electrics manufacturer Shenhua and Shanghai football team, Shanghai Shenhua Football Club was established, and China saw the formation of the first fully professional football club entirely independent of governmental institutions. In contrast, some teams like Liaoning and Bayi, rooted deeply in the earlier state-controlled sports system, struggled to realize the market-oriented operation and fully disengaged from their governmental administrative affiliations.

At the end of 1993, the Xinshijie (New World) Group sought to purchase the Liaoning football team for 4 million RMB, aiming to restructure it into a fully professionalized club under corporate management. However, conflicts soon emerged with the Liaoning Provincial Sports Commission over operational control. Just three months later, the players symbolically scraped off the “Xinshijie” logo from their jerseys, refusing to sign contracts with the company and participate in matches.

As for the Bayi team, its military affiliation created unique challenges. All adult players were active-duty soldiers and remained under the strict control of the military system. Even the youth players often came from military families or had close ties to the army. This structure meant that Bayi players consistently received lower salaries compared to those in other professional clubs, as their compensation was tied to basic military pay scales. Additionally, non-military players were unable to transfer to Bayi,

severely limiting the team's ability to recruit talent. This personnel restriction, combined with other systemic issues, eventually led to the team's disbandment in 2003 after facing scrutiny from the military's sports unit.[136]

At that time, clubs that had completely separated from government control in their day-to-day operations were in the minority. In fact, even today, the management of China's football leagues remains under strict government control. The CFA, as the governing body of the leagues, is not an independent entity. For a long time, football clubs have not been involved in high-level policy-making and decision-making processes.[137]

For those clubs that were unable to adapt to the market environment and remained under government control and traditional systems, they often faced issues in both financial and managerial aspects. Financially, traditional teams still relied on government funding, while professionalization brought the need for commercial operations. Clubs that failed to adapt to market operations generally lacked sufficient commercial sponsorship and investment, leading to a shortage of funds for player acquisitions, infrastructure development, and youth training programs. Managerially, clubs that remained under government control lacked flexible decision-making mechanisms. Bureaucratic practices and rigid management structures limited these clubs' ability to respond quickly. Compared to market-driven clubs, they were at a disadvantage in terms of decision-making efficiency, market promotion, and brand building.

The combined effect of financial and managerial issues led to a decline in player quality, coaching standards, and overall club management. As a result, these clubs' competitiveness diminished, gradually falling behind those that operated successfully in the market.

The Corruption in Chinese Football

Corruption also began to surface in Chinese football shortly after the influx of capital and the intensified competition with the backdrop of professionalization, it became unprecedentedly rampant. The earliest controversy arose during the final round of the 1999 Jia A League, in a match between Chongqing Longxin and Shenyang Haishi. Amid widespread accusations of match-fixing from fans, *S*henyang Haishi won the match 2-1 with two goals in the last minutes, securing their place in the league for the next season.[138] Both teams were subsequently fined by the Chinese Football Association for "non-competitive play", citing a lack of effort and intentional underperformance. Another notable verified match-fixing was the "Five Jia B Rats Incident" in 2001, during which five teams---Zhejiang Lucheng, Chengdu Wuniu, Changchun Yatai, Jiangsu Shuntian, and Sichuan Mianyang---in the Jia B League were accused of consecutive match-fixing, creating almost ridiculous scores of 11-2 and 6-0 in the last round, for the promotion to the Jia A League.

This event is closely tied to the policy implemented in the 2001 and 2002 Jia A and Jia B leagues, wherein promotion was permitted but relegation was suspended. The rationale for this decision was China's historic qualification for the 2002 FIFA World Cup, achieved in 2001 with the advantage of Japan and South Korea serving as hosts and thus not occupying qualifying slots. To prioritize the national team's preparation for the World Cup, the CFA announced that promotion and relegation would be suspended for the 2002 season.[139] The aim was to allow national team players to focus entirely on World Cup preparations. This decision, however, underscores the CFA's willingness to prioritize national football achievements at the cost of disrupting the regular competitive structure of the domestic league and disregarding the interests of fans. The policy not only compromised the fairness and integrity of the league but also highlighted systemic management weaknesses within the CFA, revealing deficiencies in the enforcement of league regulations and dealing a substantial blow to the league's structural foundation.

The aftermath of the match-fixing and bribing scandal left the Chinese football community and beyond in shock, even prompting demands from several state leaders for a thorough investigation. The five implicated clubs faced severe penalties, including suspension, revocation of promotion qualifications, and transfer bans. This is the first officially verified match-fixing event ever in Chinese football history. It has led to the first large-scale investigation of football betting, bribery, and match-fixing, known as the First Chinese Football Anti-corruption Campaign.

To some extent, the football professionalism reform in China exhibited notable utilitarian and short-sighted tendencies. While football was introduced to the market, it was not fully entrusted to market mechanisms. Instead, the reform was positioned as a tool to support the broader international development of Chinese football. The goal was to enhance players' motivation to engage in training by leveraging the financial and political influence of various stakeholders, thereby fostering superior athletic performance in the future. However, this short-term approach led to significant negative outcomes, such as rampant World Cup-related gambling, and the cessation of arbitrary league promotion and relegation practices pushed the league to the brink of collapse. The clash between governance and market forces led to conflicts among various interest groups at multiple levels, making disputes on the football field more frequent and complex compared to the specialized era of regional teams. While these contradictions were not immediately apparent due to the rapid transition of Chinese football, they were not adequately addressed, laying the groundwork for future conflicts which would be much more intense.

Under the various issues plaguing the Jia A League, tensions finally culminated in an incident in 2004. On October 2, during a match between Shenyang Ginde and Beijing Guoan, a controversial penalty awarded by referee Zhou Weixin to the Shenyang team led to Beijing Guoan players refusing to continue the match. After a 12-minute and 28-second interruption, Zhou declared the match over. In response, the CFA fined Beijing Guoan 300,000 RMB, awarded a 3-0 loss for the match, and deducted three points from their 2004 league standings.[140]

At this juncture, Xu Ming, the investor behind Dalian Shide, intervened and organized a coalition of seven clubs, including Beijing Guoan, to challenge the CFA, an event referred to as the "G7 Revolution." Xu was the primary instigator and leader of this movement, advocating for reforms centered on separating government from enterprise and splitting regulatory and operational functions. Zhang Hai, the investor

for Shenzhen, expressed even more radical views, highlighting the marginalization of investors in Chinese football: “Investors? What kind of investors are we? We’re treated like laborers. We put in money and effort, and all we get in return is a boxed lunch.”[141]

The G7 coalition, primarily composed of private clubs, included only one state-owned entity, Beijing Guoan, while other state-owned clubs such as Shandong Luneng and Tianjin Teda sided with the CFA. Ultimately, the G7 alliance was peacefully suppressed.[142] However, this event directly facilitated the transformation from the Jia A League to a brand new competition called the Chinese Super League (CSL) in 2004, undergoing a complete rebranding of the top-tier domestic league. The inaugural season of the CSL featured 12 clubs, with the promotion and relegation system reinstated two years later. This shift represented both a response to the G7 protests and an attempt by the CFA to further marketize and professionalize football,[143] as well as to revitalize the tarnished image of the Jia A League.[144] In April 2006, to further advance the marketization of Chinese football, the CFA, together with all CSL clubs, jointly invested in the establishment of the CSL Co., Ltd., which was tasked with managing the league. The CFA held 36% of the company’s shares as the largest shareholder.

As the environment surrounding the CSL improved, investors began to recognize the growth potential of Chinese football, subsequently directing their investments toward the sector. Significantly, even amidst ongoing investigations and trials, owners of CSL clubs increased their financial commitments, which resulted in rising attendance figures, higher television ratings, and enhanced commercial value. This thorough investigation was viewed as a vital process for eliminating harmful influences that had hindered the healthy advancement of the CSL. As a result, China’s dedication to restoring the CSL’s credibility became apparent, fostering optimism among both current and prospective investors regarding potential returns on their investments and thus laying the foundation for the league’s revival in the next ten years.

“Big Money Era”, Progress or Curse?

The Evergrande Group, a large Chinese real estate conglomerate, was the most representative example. In 2010, its owner Xu Jiayin acquired full ownership of Guangzhou Football Club for 100 million yuan and renamed it Guangzhou Evergrande Football Club. That same year, the club won the China League One championship and was promoted to CSL.[145] This substantial cash injection was followed by investments from other companies, especially real estate giants. Wanda Group Suning Holdings Group, Greenland Group, R&F Properties, and Renhe Commercial Holdings, enhancing the league’s commercialization.

This investment transformed the CSL comprehensively, evoking memories of that frenzied era 20 years prior, when the Jia A League had just begun its rapid rise. Fans returned to stadiums, the year 2012 saw the highest ticket sales since the establishment of the CSL in 2004, with attendance rates in the 2014 season reaching the highest in Asia. Players’ wages and transfer fees were both skyrocketing. The influx of foreign high-profile players and coaches became a common occurrence every transfer window or off-season. In 2017, despite the implementation of the new U23 player and foreign player regulations within the CSL, the minimum number of Chinese young players under 23 years old and the maximum number of foreign players to participate in a match was restricted, clubs still continued to bring in big-name talents. Chelsea’s Brazilian midfielder Oscar transferred to SIPG for a record-breaking 60 million EUR and became the most expensive signing in the CSL history.

By 2019, the Guangzhou Evergrande, under Xu Jiayin’s generous ownership, achieved remarkable success, winning the CSL title eight times and the AFC Champions League twice between 2011 and 2019. The significant investment and measures undertaken by stakeholders gave the club a substantial lead over others, modeling the commercialization of the league but also resulting in various negative effects. During the Big Money Era led by Xu Jiayin, in 2019, local players’ transfer fees

in the CSL approached 100 million RMB (14.36 million USD), with salaries exceeding 5 million RMB a year (0.72 million USD), ranking sixth among major leagues.[146]

Financial viability became an issue even for large real estate giants like Guangzhou Evergrande. In 2017, the league's operating loss exceeded 700 million USD, averaging over 40 million USD per club. Guangzhou Evergrande alone reported a loss of 178.5 million USD[147], constituting about 30% of the league's deficit. A four-year analysis of the top five heavily investing CSL clubs revealed inefficiency through high wage expenditure despite high league positions. The CSL's overall inefficiency stemmed from scale inefficiency, where large club sizes negatively affected operational efficiency.[148]

Additionally, international star players signed for hefty sums, hindered the growth of local talent, as young players had to compete with them for opportunities in important games. Since 2010, the disparity in the level of domestic players has directly impacted the national team's rejuvenation and the development path inconsistent with domestic leagues. During the 2010 World Cup qualifiers, China faced defeats against Iraq and Qatar, ultimately finishing at the bottom of their group and failing to qualify. In the 2014 qualifiers, they lost to Jordan and were swept by Iraq, resulting in another early exit. In the 2015 Asian Cup qualifiers, China advanced only as the best third-placed team but was eliminated in the main event after a 0-2 loss to Australia. During the 2018 World Cup qualifiers, China finished fifth in their group and failed to advance.

In other aspects, the Big Money Era of the CSL failed to promote a participatory grassroots football culture. Its fan base comprised "casuals," "The Hangers On," or "The Glory Hunters," fans attracted by market forces that temporarily boosted the football industry. A genuine fan base, devotion, and activity arise from gradual cultural development and the enhancement of football clubs. Frequent changes in club names and focuses on expensive players by sponsors and investors, while attracting public attention, hampered local talent growth and affected the club's image.

From 2010 to 2019, the money-flushed CSL experienced rapid development driven by capital, attracting numerous talented foreign players and international coaches, even referees, which enhanced the league's entertainment value and competitiveness. At the same time, it brought significant economic benefits and increased brand value. However, this rapid growth was also accompanied by several

issues, including financial risks, an underdeveloped youth training system, uneven competitive levels, and an over-reliance on foreign players. The lack of sustainability was overshadowed by the prosperity of the money bubble to some extent. However, an upcoming major shift significantly hastened the time when people became aware of the issues.

On December 31, 2019, China reported cases of unusual pneumonia in Wuhan to the World Health Organization. Human-to-human transmission of the virus was soon confirmed, raising concerns about an outbreak during the Lunar New Year travel period. By January 23, 2020, several cities in Hubei province, including Wuhan, were quarantined, and travel was suspended. The sports industry was among the first to be impacted, with ten sports venues in Wuhan closing for sterilization. On January 30, the CFA indefinitely postponed the 2020 CSL season due to the COVID-19 outbreak.

Before delving into the pandemic's impact, it is crucial to understand the CSL's mixed ownership structure. The league incorporates both state-run and privately owned teams.[149] For example, clubs like Beijing, Shandong, and Tianjin are backed by state-owned conglomerates, while others are owned by private enterprises. Though the CFA formally separated from government control in 2015 and manages on-field regulations, it remains under the National Administration of Sport's supervision. As a result, the CFA and the CSL lacked autonomy to decide when to resume the season, relying instead on instructions from the National Commission of Sports, which follows directives from the State Council.[150] This structural inefficiency and blurred responsibility within the football governance system have long been a central issue in Chinese football, exacerbated during this challenging period.

The financial impact of the pandemic further deepened the crisis. Most CSL teams suffered, receiving limited support from the CFA. Between 2020 and February 2023, reports indicate that at least 35 professional football clubs in China either ceased operations or were disbanded.[151] A significant number of these clubs were linked to the collapse of financial backing from real estate companies. This phenomenon reflects the broader dynamics of what has been termed "real estate football" in China, where the influx of capital from property developers during the big-money era of investment in Chinese football became a defining characteristic of the sport's economic structure.

The disbandment of these clubs goes beyond mere financial instability. It is a direct consequence of government regulatory policies targeting the real estate sector. Beginning in 2012, the Chinese government introduced measures to curb rising real estate prices, which had a profound impact on the financial sustainability of football clubs heavily reliant on income from property developers. These regulatory pressures were further compounded by the economic strain of the COVID-19 pandemic, during which the financial collapse of several real estate companies led to the withdrawal of their support for football clubs. As a result, many teams faced insurmountable financial challenges, forcing them to cease operations.

The intersection of real estate regulation and football financing highlights another critical part of extreme vulnerability in the economic model of Chinese football, revealing the systemic risks of overreliance on volatile industries like real estate for sustaining professional sports.[152] Although the CFA understood the financial pressures on clubs, its own financial situation was dire, with sponsors owing nearly 320 million RMB (44.82 million USD) during the pandemic. Consequently, the CFA was more likely to offer rule and policy adjustments rather than direct financial support to struggling teams.[153]

Over the following three years, the CSL witnessed a sharp decline. The 2020 Chinese Super League, delayed until July 25, adopted a centralized format in Dalian and Suzhou. Teams competed in a round-robin, with the top four from each group advancing to the championship round and the bottom four entering the relegation round, concluding after only 20 rounds. The 2021 season followed a similar centralized structure in Guangzhou and Suzhou, with 16 teams divided into two groups. The competition spanned 22 rounds across two stages: 14 in the first stage and 8 in the second. Most matches were held in empty stadiums, players were confined to hotels for extended periods, and key foreign players, like Paulinho and Anderson Talisca, were unable to return to China, resulting in the termination of their contracts. The lack of fan attendance, frequent delays in scheduling, and the exodus of star players led to a significant loss of public interest. The CFA exacerbated this by suspending the league for months to allow the national team to prepare for World Cup qualifiers, which were held overseas due to travel restrictions. These disruptions further alienated fans.[154]

The financial challenges faced by CSL clubs intensified. With no revenue from ticket sales, dwindling sponsorship deals, and broadcasters losing interest due to erratic scheduling, many clubs faced financial collapse. In February 2021, Jiangsu FC, the reigning champions owned by retail giant Suning, dissolved due to financial struggles. The financial difficulties of property developers---who owned many of the top-tier teams---further compounded the crisis. As the property market overheated, more clubs found themselves unable to cover salaries or operational expenses.[155]

Since 2015, as the CCP intensified its anti-corruption efforts, a third wave emerged during the COVID-19 pandemic, marking the largest crackdown in history. Starting with the investigation of former national team coach Li Tie in November 2022, over 10 senior officials, including former CFA chairman Chen Xuyuan and former National Commission of Sports deputy director Du Zhaocai, have been implicated. Chen was sentenced to life imprisonment in March 2024 for accepting over 81 million RMB in bribes, while Du is on trial for bribery amounting to 43.41 million RMB.

Li Tie, from 2019 to 2021, abused his position to secure bribes totaling over 50 million RMB in exchange for player selections and match-fixing. After becoming the national team coach, he signed a 60 million RMB contract with the Wuhan Zall club and controversially selected four of its players for the national team. Additionally, former CFA officials, referees, and other key figures in the football system have been implicated in widespread corruption, with match-fixing deeply ingrained in the sport from the youth level.

The football industry's ecosystem has deteriorated, with bribery rampant in every aspect of the sport, from match-fixing to project bidding and league management. The lack of separation between the CFA's organizational and supervisory roles, combined with concentrated power, has made the association a key target for corruption.

To conclude, CSL experienced a period of rapid financial growth, driven by substantial investments and sponsorships since the reformation of Jia A. However, this period, often referred to as the "Big Money Era," lacked a sustainable foundation, as clubs prioritized short-term success through inflated spending on foreign players and high salaries rather than developing infrastructure and long-term strategies. The COVID-19 pandemic exposed the inherent weaknesses in this model, including financial instability and governance challenges.

The governance of the CSL remained heavily centralized under the CFA, which retained control through a hierarchical and opaque management structure. In response to growing discontent among clubs, which sought to establish an independent league committee and operate the CSL as a market-driven entity, the CFA proposed reforms in 2019. Under the proposed governance model, the CFA would retain ownership and supervisory rights over the CSL but would relinquish control over the league's daily operations. This was an attempt to address the need for greater autonomy while maintaining oversight.

However, the pandemic led to the suspension of these reform discussions, further delaying the structural changes required for the league's long-term development. The separation of regulatory oversight from operational management remains a crucial reform, as it could provide the CSL with the autonomy necessary to foster financial sustainability and a more stable growth trajectory.

Women's Football

The trajectory of women's football in China represents one of the most dramatic reversals in modern Chinese sporting history—a meteoric rise to global prominence followed by an equally precipitous decline that mirrors broader challenges within China's sports development model. While the men's game struggled for international recognition throughout the twentieth century, as detailed in the broader Chinese football narrative, women's football achieved unprecedented heights that briefly positioned China as the dominant force in the global women's game, earning the national team the moniker "Steel Roses" before experiencing a fall that would prove more devastating than any setback faced by their male counterparts.

The foundations of organized women's football emerged much later than the men's game, beginning earnestly only in the late 1970s as part of China's broader "open-door policy" launched in 1978.[156] This timing proved fortuitous, coinciding with FIFA's official recognition of women's football in 1971 and the global football body's active promotion of the women's game under João Havelange's presidency. The germination period of the late 1970s witnessed women's football being played competitively across provinces including Shaanxi, Yunnan, and Liaoning, though participation remained minimal compared to the vibrant football culture that had previously flourished in cities like Shanghai and Hong Kong.[157] The establishment of the first "specialized" women's team in Xi'an in 1979 marked a crucial milestone, emerging from the success of inter-city girls' school competitions and receiving support from provincial sports commissions.[158]

The early 1980s brought rapid infrastructure development, beginning with the first nationwide competition in 1981 in Chuxiong, Yunnan province, and culminating in the inaugural National Women's Football Championship in Guangzhou in January 1983. By 1984, the National Sports Commission had formally ratified the establishment of the women's national team. However, this early momentum proved fragile when the exclusion of women's football from the 1984 Los Angeles Olympic Games triggered a severe setback. The National Sports Commission's response—excluding women's football from the 7th National Games—caused many local sports commissions to disband their women's teams, reducing the number of adult professional teams to just eight by 1989. This dramatic decline illustrated the vulnerability of Chinese women's

football to policy decisions driven by the Olympic-oriented development strategies that had characterized Chinese sports since the establishment of the juguo tizhi system.

The 1990s marked the golden era of Chinese women's football, beginning with the national team's gold medal at the 11th Asian Games in 1990 and their impressive performance at the inaugural Women's World Cup held in Guangzhou in 1991. The team's extraordinary achievements during this period included reaching the final of the 1996 Atlanta Olympic Games, winning four consecutive AFC Women's Championships from 1991 to 1997, and achieving their greatest moment at the 1999 Women's World Cup, where they reached the final after defeating Norway 5-0 in the semifinals.[159] During this golden period, the Chinese women's team earned the designation "Steel Roses," a term instituted by FIFA to validate the strength and power of women's football, and received praise from President Jiang Zemin for their "invaluable spiritual treasure" and dedication to bringing glory to the motherland.

The new millennium brought dramatic reversal. After reaching tournament finals in 1996 and 1999, Chinese women's football suffered a precipitous fall that continues to the present day. The team's FIFA ranking plummeted from fifth when rankings began in 2003 to 18th by 2012, with particularly poor showings including an 8-0 defeat by Germany at the 2004 Athens Olympics. The China Women's Super League, which had operated on a home-and-away basis since 1997, was suspended in 2005 as clubs could no longer afford operational costs, with matches attracting fewer than 100 spectators.[160]

This decline reflected deeper structural problems that paralleled the challenges facing Chinese football more broadly during the professionalization era. By 2011, only 16 adult teams participated in the National Women's Football League, while the number of registered women footballers nationwide stood at approximately 10,000—a minuscule figure compared to Germany's 1,000,000 or the United States' 3,000,000. The marginalization extended to media coverage, with analysis revealing that only 0.008% of newspaper reports mentioned women's football between 2000 and 2011.[161] Parental attitudes surveys revealed that more than 40% of respondents believed football was unsuitable for girls, with only 21.67% willing to allow their daughters to pursue careers in women's football.

The women's football story thus represents both the potential and the limitations of China's state-sponsored sporting development model. The remarkable achievements

of the 1990s were built on centralized investment and policy support, but proved unsustainable without broader popular participation and grassroots development. Unlike the men's game, which had deep historical roots in school and social football dating back to the colonial period, women's football lacked the cultural foundation necessary for long-term sustainability. The brief flowering of the "Steel Roses" ultimately became a cautionary tale about the fragility of elite sporting success divorced from systematic foundation-building and cultural acceptance—a pattern that would later manifest in different forms across Chinese football during the tumultuous periods of professionalization, corruption scandals, and the "Big Money Era" that followed.

Post-Chaos Present and Path Forward

The restoration of the home-and-away system in the 2022 season marked a pivotal turning point for Chinese football, signaling its gradual recovery from the disruptions caused by the COVID-19 pandemic. By the 2023 season, normalcy was largely restored, and the CSL regained its traditional structure, allowing teams to reconnect with their fan bases and rebuild matchday atmospheres. This transition also underscored broader challenges: financial instability, fluctuating club performance, and the need for sustainable development strategies.

Politically, Chinese football has been significantly shaped by recent government directives, especially under President Xi Jinping's leadership. Xi, a well-known football enthusiast, has personally prioritized the development of football in China as part of the broader national strategy for sports. In 2015, the State Council issued a comprehensive reform plan for football, aiming to make China a powerhouse by 2050. This document emphasized increasing grassroots participation, improving professional league structures, and promoting Chinese football on the global stage.

Under Xi's vision, football is seen as not only a sport but a means of bolstering national pride and international influence. Various guidelines and policy documents have since been rolled out to implement these reforms, focusing on youth academies, professional training programs, and upgrading infrastructure. In 2020, the Chinese Football Association released its "Football Reform and Development Plan," aligned with Xi's ambitions, setting clear goals for enhancing national competitiveness and establishing a sustainable football culture.[162]

Looking ahead, the future of Chinese football hinges on these structural reforms that prioritize long-term investments in youth development, infrastructure, and grassroots engagement. Integrating data-driven analysis and sports science into training and player development could position China more competitively on the international

stage. The promotion of consistent performance across domestic and international competitions will require sustained efforts in these areas.

Ultimately, Xi's political commitment and the government's active role through policy guidelines reflect a strategic shift. The future of Chinese football, in this vision, is not just about economic revival but about fostering a football culture that nurtures local talent, empowering Chinese football to transcend its past challenges and establish a stable, prosperous future in the post-pandemic world.

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